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AUTOANTS RESEARCH · Q4 2026

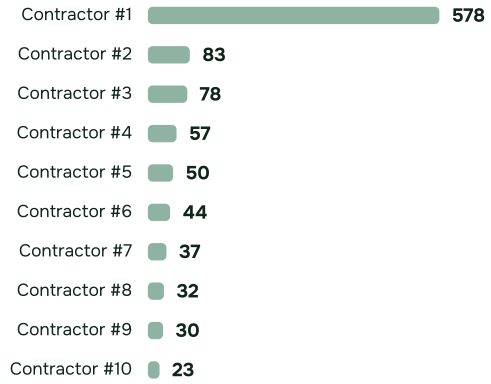
State of New Orleans HVAC

Public records only: city permits, our own check of local HVAC websites, what AI assistants say, and government data. No company is named except where an AI assistant named it.

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Ten contractors pulled 50% of Orleans HVAC permits in the last 12 months

EXHIBIT 1 HVAC permits by contractor, Orleans Parish, 2025-10-01 to 2026-09-30



Permits are a proxy for installs and replacements, not repairs. Other contractors are shown by rank: the city records the license holder, not the company.

Source: City of New Orleans open data, "Permits - BLDS" (data.nola.gov dataset 72f9-bi28), https://data.nola.gov/resource/72f9-bi28.json, permits issued 2025-10-01 to 2026-09-30

CAN A CUSTOMER BOOK YOU FROM A PHONE?

16 of 45

local HVAC sites can't be booked from the first phone screen.

- **22** Book button on the first screen
- **4** Button plus a time promise
- **6** Booking below the first screen
- **10** No way to book online
- **3** Unclear or didn't load

Source: autoants first-screen check of New Orleans-area HVAC websites, 2026-10-12: 45 live sites (51 checked; 6 left out: 3 didn't load, 2 showed an error page, 1 stayed blank)

WHO AI ASSISTANTS RECOMMEND

Natal's Air Conditioning, Plumbing & Electrical, Stuart Services were named most; you weren't named.

Source: The New Orleans AI Recommendation Index · October 2026 (autoants, draft edition data content/ai-index/2026-10/data.json), asked 2026-10-05

16 of 45 New Orleans HVAC sites can't be booked from the first phone screen

EXHIBIT 2 **What a customer sees first on each shop's phone homepage**



A customer comparing shops on a phone picks the one that shows when it can come. A visible next-available time does that without a call.

Source: autoants first-screen check of New Orleans-area HVAC websites, 2026-10-12: 45 live sites (51 checked; 6 left out: 3 didn't load, 2 showed an error page, 1 stayed blank)

22

A Book, Schedule or Request Service button is on the first phone screen, but no time is promised (it often opens a contact form).

6

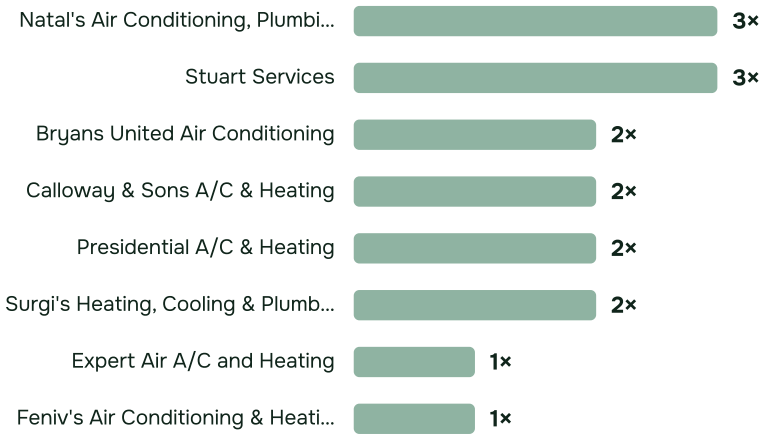
A real booking or request control exists, but it sits below the first phone screen.

10

No booking or request control anywhere on the homepage.

When customers ask an AI assistant for the best HVAC company, these are the names it gives

EXHIBIT 3 Companies named by AI assistants for New Orleans HVAC questions



Source: The New Orleans AI Recommendation Index · October 2026 (autoants, draft edition data content/ai-index/2026-10/data.json); assistant: Claude (Anthropic), web search on, via claude -p (products/video-audit/ai_ask.py); 'times' = how many of the 3 answers offered the company as one to call or consider (passing mentions and warnings not counted), asked 2026-10-05

WHAT WE ASKED

"What's the best air conditioning repair company in New Orleans? Give me your top recommendations."

"My AC died tonight in New Orleans. Who should I call? Name specific companies."

"Recommend a reliable HVAC company in New Orleans, Louisiana with great reviews."

Half of Orleans homes were built before 1960 and the cooling season runs most of the year. The work isn't going away.

50%

of Orleans homes were built before 1960

U.S. Census Bureau, American Community Survey 5-year estimates, tables B25034 (Year Structure Built) and B25035 (Median Year Structure Built), ACS 5-year 2024 (2020-2024)

41

plumbing and HVAC businesses with paid staff based in Orleans; 240 in Jefferson

U.S. Census Bureau, County Business Patterns 2023

$30.53

median hourly wage for this trade in the New Orleans metro

U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Employment and Wage Statistics, May 2025

3,206

cooling degree days a year, vs 1,176 for heating

NOAA NCEI U.S. Climate Normals 1991-2020 (annual/seasonal)

RULE CHANGES THAT REACH YOUR SHOP

took effect 2023-01-01

New efficiency rating (SEER2)

In Louisiana, new split ACs installed from this date must meet 14.3 SEER2.

10 CFR 430.32(c)(5)-(6) (eCFR, current 2026-10-01)

took effect 2023-09-01

Business texting must be registered

Carriers began blocking texts from unregistered business numbers (10DLC).

Twilio changelog, '[U.S. A2P 10DLC] Full blocking of traffic sent...

took effect 2025-01-01

New refrigerant rule

No new home AC systems made or imported with R-410A-class refrigerant; R-454B and R-32 replace it.

40 CFR 84.54(a)(1) and (c)(1) (eCFR, current 2026-10-01)

took effect 2026-07-27
published 2026-05-26

Install deadline relaxed

Split systems built from pre-2025 parts may still be installed, with no deadline.

EPA final rule, Phasedown of Hydrofluorocarbons: Reconsideration of...

Context from government sources only, dated. Every figure is dated under it.

How this was made

1. **Permits:** the City of New Orleans open permit data, last 12 full months. The city records the license holder, not the company, so contractors are shown by rank only.
2. **Booking readiness:** our own check of local websites on a phone, counted, never named.
3. **AI answers:** the New Orleans AI Recommendation Index, as recorded on the date shown.
4. **Context:** the Census Bureau, the Bureau of Labor Statistics and NOAA, each dated under its figure.

WANT THIS FOR YOUR OWN SHOP?

We do the same homework on one business, then add a 45-minute interview about how your business runs, from the first call to getting paid; a written report on what to fix first, and what to leave alone; and a 30-minute walkthrough of what we found. The report is bound and printed, with its own report number. $500, credited toward setup if you continue.

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